January 2021 and the unremorseful view of the participants show how far America's Lebanonization has gone. Joe Biden as president will lead a deeply divided country: over 70 million Americans voted for Trump, only 3–4 million less than for Biden. Trump or a Trumpist Republican including a member of his family may run for election in 2024 – and who is to say that he or a political clone will not win? Before then, we can imagine a period of upheaval and violence, including against the US leadership and its legislators.

What about China's internal politics? Are Xi and the communist party firmly in control? It is hard to know. Chinese politics is so far removed from public scrutiny that all kinds of views exist about the future of China. A high-level communist party official who for years was an influential professor at the Central Party School in Beijing recently fled to the US. In late 2020, Cai Xia published an account of her career and her disillusionment with China's government including President Xi. In her essay in the influential American journal *Foreign Affairs*, she argues that Xi is brutally authoritarian, divorced from political and economic and perhaps even geopolitical realities, and unwilling to commit to the next generation of reforms. She writes: 'China's long-standing problems of corruption, excessive debt, and unprofitable state enterprises are rooted in party officials' power to meddle in economic decisions without public supervision.'[22] These are the standard ills that critics of China have long highlighted. Will they lead to large-scale unrest and the collapse of the present regime? Cai Xia avoids that conclusion, but she gestures at the possibility of growing internal dissatisfaction. Another dissident now living in the US, Deng Yuwen, also formerly of the Central Party School, suggests that reformists may be biding their time: 'Based on my observations, a considerable number of reformists inside the party are despairing, like Cai Xia . . . But for the most part they put the blame on Xi Jinping and are waiting for some kind of error by Xi to reinvigorate reformist forces within the party.'[23]

A contrary view relies less on the disillusionment of party insiders and elites and more on popular opinion to gauge internal stability. According to